
SPEAK ENGLISH WITH CLASS

English Leap Podcast

How to Speak English Confidently?



Erin: Hey there, English learners! Welcome back to The English Leap Podcast—your go-to podcast for learning English in a fun, natural, and engaging way. I’m Erin, and as always, I’m here with my fantastic co-host, Evan!

Evan: Hey, everyone! So glad to be here! Erin, I have to say, I’m really looking forward to today’s episode. We’re diving into a topic that can truly help our listeners level up their English and sound more polished and confident.

Erin: Absolutely! Whether you’re at work, in a meeting, or even just having a casual conversation, the way you speak matters. And today, we’re breaking down key strategies that will help you instantly sound more professional and polished.

Evan: And you know what, Erin? This reminds me—have you ever had one of those moments where you say something, and then immediately think, “Wait... did that sound way too casual?”

Erin: Oh, all the time! I remember once in a formal meeting, I greeted everyone with “Hey, what’s up?” instead of “Good morning.”

Evan: Haha, I can imagine! And that’s exactly why this topic is so important. We’ll be sharing practical, easy-to-apply strategies to help you avoid common mistakes, refine your speech, and boost your confidence.

Erin: And to make sure you get the most out of today’s episode, we’ve created a free PDF guide with key takeaways, plus comprehension questions and grammar exercises to help you practice and improve your confidence.

Evan: Yep! If you want to review today's tips and keep improving, make sure to grab the PDF. The link is in the description!

Erin: Oh, And of course, we'll also be introducing a handful of intermediate-level words and phrases throughout the episode.

Evan: That's right! And later in the episode, we'll break them down in Charlotte's Vocabulary Section, where Charlotte will explain their meanings and show you how to use them naturally in real-life conversations.

Erin: So don't go anywhere! Today, you're going to learn powerful communication tips and expand your vocabulary.

Evan: Alright, Erin... are you ready?

Erin: Oh, I was born ready, Evan!

Evan: Haha, love it! Let's dive into today's topic—how to sound more polished and confident when speaking English. Whether you're in a meeting, on a call, or just having a casual conversation, the way you speak makes a huge difference in how people perceive you.

Erin: Exactly! And you know, Evan, a lot of times people don't even realize that small tweaks in their speech can make them sound way more polished and confident.

Evan: So true! And that's why we're breaking it down into eight key strategies today. Let's start with the first one...

1. Use Proper Greetings

Erin: One of the easiest ways to instantly sound more professional is by using proper greetings. Instead of saying "Hey" or "What's up?" in a professional setting, go for: "Good morning." "Good afternoon." "Hello, how are you today?" It might seem like a small detail, but trust me, it sets the tone for the entire conversation.

Evan: Absolutely! And here's another tip—use people's titles and last names unless they tell you otherwise. So instead of saying, "Hey, John," say, "Good morning, Mr. Smith."

Erin: Right! Because addressing someone formally shows respect and professionalism.

2. Avoid Verbose and Wordy Language

Erin: Now, another mistake that makes people sound less professional is being too wordy. Some people think that using big, complex sentences makes them sound smarter, but actually... it does the opposite!

Evan: Yes! Being concise is key. The more direct and clear you are, the more confident you sound. Instead of using long, unnecessary phrases, simplify them. Let's go through some examples.

Erin: That's a great point, Evan! Here's an example—instead of saying "In the event that it rains, we will postpone the meeting," just say "If it rains, we will postpone the meeting." Same meaning, but it's shorter, clearer, and easier to understand.

Evan: Exactly! Here's another one—rather than saying "For the purpose of improving our customer service, we are launching a new training program," just say "To improve our customer service, we are launching a new training program." It gets straight to the point without unnecessary words.

Erin: Much better! Let's try one more—instead of saying "Due to the fact that she was late, the meeting started without her," simply say "Because she was late, the meeting started without her."

Evan: See how much crisper and more professional that sounds? Less is more when it comes to clear communication! Think about great speakers—they don't waste words!

3. Eliminate Filler Words and Side Particles

Erin: Exactly! And that brings us to our next point—eliminating filler words.

Evan: Oh yes, this is a big one! Filler words like “um,” “like,” “you know,” and “kind of” can make you sound unsure of yourself.

Erin: And the tricky thing? Most of us don’t even realize we’re using them! I remember listening to a recording of myself once, and I was shocked at how many times I said “like” in just one sentence.

Evan: Oh, I’ve been there! It’s so easy to slip into the habit. Like instead of saying, “I kind of think this idea might work,” you could just say, “I believe this idea will work.” See how much stronger that sounds?

Erin: Exactly! And here’s a quick tip—if you catch yourself about to say a filler word, just pause instead. A short silence actually makes you sound more confident than filling the gap with “um” or “like.”

Evan: That’s such a great trick! And another thing to watch out for is side particles—words like “basically,” “technically,” or “actually.” They often don’t add any real value to what you’re saying.

Erin: Right! Instead of saying, “Basically, we need to finish the report by Friday,” just say, “We need to finish the report by Friday.” Simple, clear, and professional.

Evan: Love it! The less cluttered your speech is, the more confident and authoritative you’ll sound.

4. Use Power Words for Confidence

Erin: Now, speaking of confidence, one of the best ways to sound more professional is by choosing strong, assertive words.

Evan: Oh, I love this one! The way you phrase things completely changes how people perceive you. If you sound unsure, others might not take your ideas seriously.

Erin: Exactly! Let’s go through some common phrases that people use without realizing they sound uncertain—and how to make them stronger.

Evan: Alright, here's one—instead of saying “I think this is a good idea,” say “I believe this is a great idea.” It makes you sound confident rather than doubtful.

Erin: Yes! And here's another one—instead of saying “I was given an opportunity,” say “I seized the opportunity.” That small change makes it clear that you took action, rather than just receiving something passively.

Evan: That's a good one! What about this—instead of saying “Maybe we could try this approach,” say “Let's move forward with this approach.” It's much more decisive.

Erin: I love that! And here's a really common one—instead of asking “Does that make sense?” ask “Let me know if you have any questions.” The first one makes it sound like you're doubting yourself, while the second one keeps things open but confident.

Evan: Oh, that's a great point! And for the last one—instead of saying “I hope this helps,” say “I'm confident this will help.” It shows certainty rather than just hoping for the best.

Erin: Exactly! These small changes might seem minor, but they instantly make you sound more confident and professional.

Evan: So true! It's not about being aggressive—it's about speaking with clarity and certainty. Making these tweaks will help you sound more polished and persuasive.

5. Avoid Disclaimers That Weaken Your Message

Erin: Alright, here's something that a lot of people don't realize—adding unnecessary disclaimers can actually weaken your message.

Evan: Oh, I know exactly what you mean! People sometimes say things like, “This might sound silly, but...” or “You've probably already thought of this, but...” before sharing an idea.

Erin: Exactly! And when you start with a disclaimer, you make it seem like your point isn't important or isn't worth considering.

Evan: Right! Instead of saying, “I’m not sure if this is a good idea, but maybe we could try...” just own it and say, “I suggest we try...”

Erin: Yes! Here’s another one—instead of saying “This may be a dumb question, but...” just ask, “Can you clarify this for me?” It sounds confident and professional.

Evan: I love that! If you believe in what you’re saying, there’s no need to apologize for it.

Erin: Exactly! Removing these unnecessary disclaimers makes you sound more sure of yourself—and that makes others more likely to listen to you.

6. Give Polite and Constructive Feedback

Evan: Alright, Erin, let’s talk about something that’s really important in professional settings—giving feedback.

Erin: Yes! Feedback is necessary for growth, but how you say it makes all the difference.

Evan: Right! If you’re too harsh, you could hurt someone’s confidence. But if you’re too vague, they won’t know what to improve.

Erin: Exactly! So instead of saying, “Your work isn’t good,” say, “I think this could be improved by...” That way, you’re offering a solution instead of just criticizing.

Evan: Yes! And instead of saying, “You did this wrong,” say, “I have a suggestion that might make this even better.” It’s positive and constructive.

Erin: That’s such a great tip! Another good approach is starting with something positive before giving feedback. For **Example:** “I really like how you structured this report. One way we can make it even stronger is by adding more details in this section.”

Evan: Yes! That way, the person feels encouraged instead of discouraged. Feedback should help people grow, not bring them down.

7. Ask Questions Professionally

Erin: Now, Evan, I know you'll agree with me on this—the way you ask questions can completely change how professional you sound.

Evan: Oh, absolutely! If you ask vague or unstructured questions, it can come across as unclear or even unprofessional.

Erin: Right! Instead of saying, “Uh... I don't get it,” try something more polished, like: “Excuse me, may I ask...?”

Evan: Or instead of “Can you explain that again?” say: “I was wondering if you could clarify...”

Erin: Yes! And another great way to sound professional is to ask for more details in a structured way. Instead of just saying, “What do you mean?” try: “Could you elaborate on that?”

Evan: I love that! The way you frame your question affects how people perceive your confidence and engagement. If you ask well-structured questions, you show that you're paying attention and actively participating.

Erin: Exactly! And once you've asked your question, really listen to the response. Communication is a two-way street.

Evan: So true! Asking clear, professional questions makes you sound more confident, prepared, and engaged.

8. Close Conversations Professionally

Erin: Alright, last but definitely not least—how you end a conversation matters just as much as how you start it!

Evan: Oh, 100%! If you end a conversation too abruptly, it can seem rushed or even rude.

Erin: Exactly! Instead of just saying “Okay, bye,” say: “Thank you for your time and valuable insights.” or “I appreciate the opportunity to discuss this with you.”

Evan: And if next steps are involved, make that clear. Instead of saying, “I’ll follow up,” say, “I’ll send you an update by Friday.”

Erin: Yes! And if you’re in a professional setting, you can also invite future communication. Instead of just saying “Talk later,” say, “Please feel free to reach out if you have any further questions.”

Evan: Perfect! Closing professionally and politely leaves a positive impression and makes you sound more polished.

Erin: That wraps up our conversation on how to speak more professionally—from using proper greetings to eliminating filler words and speaking with confidence.

Evan: Absolutely! And now, it’s time for Charlotte’s Vocabulary Section! Charlotte, take it away!

Charlotte: Thanks, Evan! Hello again, English learners! In today’s episode, Erin and Evan introduced some great words related to professional communication. Let’s break down a few of them so you can start using them with confidence.

Perceive

Meaning: To recognize, understand, or interpret something in a particular way.

Example: “Many people perceive public speaking as stressful, but with practice, it becomes easier.”

Tweaks

Meaning: Small changes or adjustments to improve something.

Example: “A few tweaks to your email can make it sound more professional.”

Verbose

Meaning: Using more words than necessary, often making something difficult to understand.

Example: “The professor asked him to simplify his verbose essay into a more concise version.”

Polished

Meaning: Refined, well-prepared, or professionally presented.

Example: “Her polished presentation impressed the entire boardroom.”

Concise

Meaning: Expressing something clearly in as few words as possible.

Example: “A concise summary of your skills will make your résumé more effective.”

Crisp

Meaning: Clear, fresh, or precise.

Example: “She gave a crisp and well-organized report during the meeting.”

Assertive

Meaning: Confidently expressing oneself without being aggressive.

Example: “Being assertive in negotiations helps you stand your ground professionally.”

Aggressive

Meaning: Forceful or pushy, often in a negative way.

Example: “A polite but firm approach is more effective than being aggressive in discussions.”

Persuasive

Meaning: Able to convince others effectively.

Example: “Her persuasive speech earned her the top prize in the debate competition.”

Disclaimer

Meaning: A statement that clarifies or limits responsibility.

Example: “The advertisement included a disclaimer noting that results may vary.”

Criticize

Meaning: To express disapproval or point out mistakes.

Example: “Instead of criticizing your teammate’s work, offer constructive feedback.”

Charlotte: That’s it for today’s vocabulary breakdown! Try using these words in your conversations this week. The more you practice, the more natural they’ll feel! Back to you, Erin and Evan!

Erin: Thanks, Charlotte! That was super helpful!

Evan: Absolutely! Expanding your vocabulary is key to sounding more professional and polished.

Erin: And don’t forget—if you want to review today’s key takeaways, grab our free PDF guide with vocabulary exercises and practice questions. The link is in the description!

Evan: If you enjoyed this episode, follow, subscribe, and leave a review! It helps us keep creating content just for you.

Erin: And most importantly—keep practicing, keep learning, and keep improving!

Exercise 1: Sentence Refinement (Grammar & Clarity)

◆ **Instructions:** Rewrite the following sentences to make them **more concise, professional, and articulate**.

1. Due to the fact that we had limited time, we were unable to complete the project.
2. In the event that you need assistance, please do not hesitate to reach out.
3. I think maybe we could try a different approach.
4. This might sound silly, but I have an idea.
5. I was given the opportunity to lead the project.

💡 **Tip:** Focus on **removing unnecessary words, eliminating disclaimers, and using strong, direct language.**

📌 Exercise 2: Vocabulary in Context (Comprehension & Usage)

♦ **Instructions:** Fill in the blanks with the correct word from the vocabulary list (**perceive, articulate, assertive, concise, persuasive**).

1. She delivered a _____ presentation that convinced everyone to support her idea.
2. A good leader must be _____, expressing ideas confidently without being aggressive.
3. It's important to be _____ in emails to ensure your message is clear and professional.
4. He struggled to _____ his thoughts under pressure, making his argument less effective.
5. People often _____ silence as disinterest, but sometimes it's just a moment of reflection.

💡 **Tip:** Review Charlotte's Vocabulary Section for definitions before answering!

📌 Exercise 3: Identify & Correct Filler Words (Grammar & Speech Refinement)

♦ **Instructions:** Read the sentences below and **remove or replace** unnecessary filler words like "um," "like," "you know," "kind of," "basically," "actually."

1. I was actually kind of thinking that maybe we could, like, try a new approach.
2. Um, I think, you know, we should basically focus on the key points first.
3. She's, like, a really, really great speaker, you know?
4. He basically told me that, um, the meeting was postponed until, like, next week.
5. I kind of feel like this might be a good solution, actually.

💡 **Tip:** Aim for **clear and confident** statements without unnecessary fillers!

📌 Exercise 4: Comprehension Check (Listening & Understanding)

♦ **Instructions:** Answer the following questions based on today's episode discussion.

1. Why is using proper greetings important in professional settings?
2. What is one way to make your speech more **concise and direct**?
3. How do **filler words** affect how you sound in conversations?
4. What does it mean to be **assertive** when speaking?
5. Why should you avoid disclaimers like "This might be a silly question, but..."?

💡 **Tip:** Try answering these in **full sentences** to practice fluency and articulation.

📌 Answers Section

♦ **Exercise 1: Sentence Refinement (Answers)**

1. *Because we had limited time, we couldn't complete the project.*
 2. *If you need assistance, please reach out.*
 3. *We should try a different approach.*
 4. *I have an idea.*
 5. *I seized the opportunity to lead the project.*
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♦ Exercise 2: Vocabulary in Context (Answers)

1. **Persuasive** – *She delivered a persuasive presentation that convinced everyone to support her idea.*
 2. **Assertive** – *A good leader must be assertive, expressing ideas confidently without being aggressive.*
 3. **Concise** – *It's important to be concise in emails to ensure your message is clear and professional.*
 4. **Articulate** – *He struggled to articulate his thoughts under pressure, making his argument less effective.*
 5. **Perceive** – *People often perceive silence as disinterest, but sometimes it's just a moment of reflection.*
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♦ Exercise 3: Removing Fillers (Answers)

1. *I think we should try a new approach.*
 2. *We should focus on the key points first.*
 3. *She's a great speaker.*
 4. *He told me the meeting was postponed until next week.*
 5. *I believe this might be a good solution.*
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♦ Exercise 4: Comprehension Check (Sample Answers)

1. *Proper greetings set a respectful and professional tone at the start of a conversation.*
2. *To be more concise, avoid wordy phrases and use direct language, such as replacing "Due to the fact that" with "Because."*
3. *Filler words like "um" and "like" can make you sound unsure and less confident.*
4. *Being assertive means speaking confidently and clearly without being aggressive or rude.*
5. *Disclaimers weaken your message and make you sound uncertain, so it's better to state your point directly.*

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